

Uttar Pradesh doesn't mean that her so called "magic" formula would work elsewhere too. Her track record of governance is poor and there are many skeletons hidden in her closet, all gathered during her tenures as Uttar Pradesh's chief minister. Her ruthless attempt to be projected as an "icon" for billions of Indians is nothing but wishful thinking and her loud claims to be the prime minister of the country is just another pipe dream.

K.M.G. VIVEKANANDAM,  
Madurai

## Legal Trouble

The court's ruling against the Mehtas' plea to abort their baby must have left them distraught ("Right to Live", August 18). And assurances that their baby would survive and lead a normal life would have provided little comfort to them at this hour, knowing well that their baby would be born with a congenital heart disease. Just like having a baby, aborting a baby should also be a matter of personal choice and the prerogative of the parents concerned. The law and social ethics should not govern such personal decisions. The MTP Act needs to be changed.

MAHESH KUMAR, on e-mail

## Terror Turmoil

We follow the formula—to condemn, console and compensate. Our political leaders first condemn terrorist attack, then console the victims of the attacks and finally pay ex-gratia to compensate the loss of a life. It is a great irony that on one hand we proclaim war against terror and on

the other we pardon the person pronounced guilty for the attack on Parliament. Is it because none of the so-called VIPs were killed during the attack? Why do common people have to bear the brunt always?

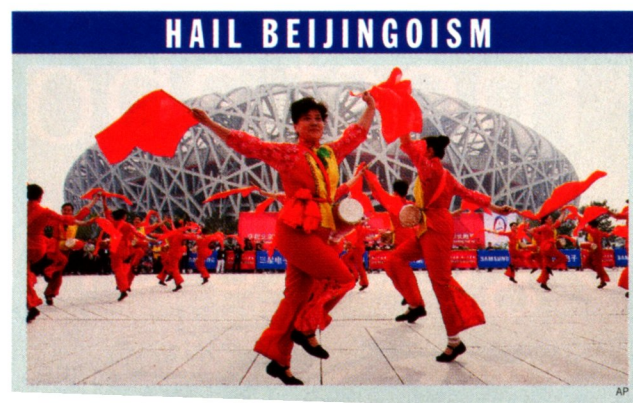
SANJEEV SAHAY, Ahmedabad

## Burning Issue

The row over Amarnath shrine land allotment has been blown out of proportion by the separatists who see it as an issue between

the Valley and the rest of India ("Fanning the Flames", August 18). Why on earth do the separatists and their cohorts, both of whom are fired by religious fanaticism, oppose allotment of a piece of land for the use of the pilgrims for a limited period of two months especially when the yatra contributes significantly to the economy of the Valley? Does it amount to demographic change? Their stand defies all logic.

R.J. KHURANA, Bhopal



China's obsessive resolve to leave no stone unturned to bag gold medals in the Olympics is a clear reflection of the stupendously growing and the world's most populous nation's almost ruthless ambition to usurp the superpower status from the US, come what may ("Beijing's Big Bang", August 18, 2008). Surmounting hurdles like the worldwide protests for the Tibetan cause, the devastating earthquake and stifling air pollution, China has viewed the hosting of the Games as an opportunity to showcase its assiduously built nation to the rest of the world. Never mind its pathetic track-record of next to nil human rights and the trauma that the people of the nation were put through in the bargain.

NALINI VIJAYARAGHAVAN, on e-mail

Beijing Games will go down in the annals of history for record-breaking attempts by Michael Phelps. With everything timed around the number eight, Phelps has also rocked the show with his haul of eight gold medals.

ROHIT KUMAR, Mumbai

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# 30

Years Ago in India Today

SEPTEMBER 16-30, 1978



Phoolvati

## Point of No Return

Twenty-year-old Phoolvati leans against the wall of the refugee camp, holding her one-and-a-half-year-old son. As she stares out into the distance, she wonders whether her husband, Ram Kishen, is dead or alive. The Delhi administration did warn them that Jehangirpuri was in danger of being submerged under water. But few took them seriously. Phoolvati wanted to move but her husband told her to stop being stupid. The floods came suddenly with a vengeance as predicted on Monday, September 4. Phoolvati holds her son tightly, remembering the nightmare that followed. As panic swept, people ran out blindly into the rising waters, clutching their children and whatever belongings they could lay their hands on. The children clung hard to their parents. Those who couldn't hold on, slipped and disappeared into the swirling waters. Their parents didn't have the time to stop and search for them.

—Anil R. Jorath